

MARIA V. SANTACRUZ

Chicago, IL | 773-715-6231 | mmsantacruz01@gmail.com | LinkedIn | Cybersecurity Portfolio

Aspiring Cybersecurity Analyst with 10+ years of experience analyzing data, safeguarding sensitive information, enforcing policies, and resolving operational issues in fast-paced environments. Currently completing the Google Cybersecurity Professional Certificate with hands-on experience in Linux, SQL, Splunk, Wireshark, Tcpdump, Suricata, Python, and security monitoring through TryHackMe labs. Skilled in log analysis, vulnerability assessment, network security, and incident investigation, with a strong foundation in security frameworks and threat detection. Recognized for analytical problem-solving, attention to detail, collaboration, and maintaining accuracy under pressure.

RELEVANT SKILLS & EXPERTISE

Tools/Languages: Linux, Windows, SQL, Splunk, WireShark, Tcpdump, Suricata, Python, ChatGPT

Security Practices: Information Security, Network Security, Vulnerability Assessment, Threat Analysis, Log Analysis, Security Frameworks and Controls

Software Platforms: Google Workspace, Slack

Strengths: Problem-Solving, Collaboration, Attention to Detail, Calmness Under Pressure

CYBERSECURITY PROJECTS

TryHackMe Rooms: Utilized interactive, gamified virtual environment to enhance practical knowledge and hands-on skills:

- **Linux Fundamentals** (1, 2, & 3) and **Linux Strength Training** - Navigated directories and files, adjusted permissions, analyzed logs, explored common utilities
 - **Intro to Logs** and **Log Analysis** - Identified log types, located logs, employed regular expressions (RegEx), and utilized command line and CyberChef for effective log analysis
 - **Wireshark Basics** and **Wireshark 101** - Gained proficiency in packet dissection, navigation, and filtering techniques; analyzed ARP, ICMP, TCP, DNS, HTTP, and HTTPS traffic for network troubleshooting and security analysis
 - **Windows Fundamentals** (1, 2, & 3) and **Windows Forensics** (1 & 2) - Acquired fundamental understanding of Windows, including file systems, user account control (UAC), control panel, system configuration, security, firewall, registry, and FAT/NTFS file systems; developed skills in accessing hives, utilizing registry explorer, and recovering files
 - **Splunk Basics**, **Incident Handling with Splunk**, and **Splunk** (2 & 3) - Developed skills in navigating Splunk; conducting incident handling using Splunk; participated in the Boss of the SOC investigation for security analysis
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PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Multiple • Fabulash, Chicago, IL

04/2016 - 12/2025

Business Analyst

- Analyzed employee timesheets and payroll records to verify hours worked and process accurate weekly payroll, ensuring data integrity and reducing payroll discrepancies.
- Validated daily financial transactions, appointments, and payment records to identify inconsistencies, maintaining accurate business records and operational reliability.
- Reviewed weekly and monthly financial reports, including bank statements and bookkeeping records, to detect discrepancies and support accurate financial reconciliation.
- Monitored daily business operations, employee attendance, and system readiness to ensure operational continuity and minimize workflow disruptions.
- Coordinated scheduling, email communications, phone inquiries, and service requests to maintain organized operations and timely issue resolution.
- Implemented standardized operational procedures and scheduling practices to improve process consistency, accountability, and service delivery.
- Tracked business performance metrics, payroll expenses, and operational costs to support informed decision-making and maintain financial stability.
- Maintained confidential employee and financial records while exercising discretion and accuracy when handling sensitive business information.

Client Relations

- Developed clear client policies and service guidelines to establish expectations, reduce misunderstandings, and improve compliance with business procedures.
- Resolved customer inquiries and scheduling conflicts by assessing situations, communicating policy requirements, and implementing appropriate solutions to maintain client satisfaction.
- Managed client communications through email, phone, text messaging, and social media, ensuring timely responses and consistent customer support.

- Leveraged digital marketing platforms, including Groupon and social media, to attract new clients, increasing customer acquisition and business growth.
- Built long-term client relationships through professional communication, transparency, and trust, resulting in high client retention and referral-based business growth.
- Documented client appointments, service requests, and scheduling updates to maintain accurate records and support operational efficiency.
- Identified scheduling risks and appointment conflicts early, implementing corrective actions to minimize service disruptions and optimize resource utilization.

Associate • The Lash Spot, Chicago, IL

04/2014 - 04/2016

- Delivered personalized client support by assessing customer needs and recommending appropriate service options, improving customer satisfaction and trust.
- Built strong client relationships through professional communication and consistent service, increasing customer retention and repeat business.
- Communicated service expectations, procedures, and appointment details to ensure customer understanding and minimize scheduling issues.
- Maintained accurate client records and appointment information, supporting organized documentation and efficient daily operations.
- Resolved client questions and concerns promptly by evaluating issues and providing appropriate solutions, enhancing the overall customer experience.
- Verified appointment details and service selections to ensure accuracy and reduce operational errors before service delivery.
- Applied established business policies and service procedures consistently, promoting compliance with organizational standards and a positive customer experience.

Manager • Cafe Bacci, Chicago, IL

2009 - 2014

- Supervised daily business operations and employee activities to ensure operational continuity, efficient workflow, and consistent customer service.
- Coordinated employee schedules based on staffing needs, optimizing workforce coverage and minimizing operational disruptions.
- Processed payroll records by verifying employee hours and maintaining accurate documentation, ensuring timely and error-free payroll administration.
- Monitored cash register operations and financial transactions to maintain accuracy, accountability, and compliance with established cash-handling procedures.
- Resolved customer concerns and operational issues by assessing situations and implementing timely solutions, improving service quality and team efficiency.
- Verified daily operational readiness by ensuring employees were present, resources were available, and business processes were functioning as expected.
- Enforced company policies and operational procedures to promote consistency, accountability, and compliance across daily operations.
- Collaborated with staff to maintain efficient service during high-volume periods, reducing delays and supporting business continuity.
- Maintained accurate operational, payroll, and scheduling records while handling sensitive employee information with discretion and attention to detail.

EDUCATION, CERTIFICATES, & CERTIFICATIONS

Google Cybersecurity Professional Certificate • Merit America, Virtual

11/2026

- Cultivated holistic understanding of cybersecurity's critical role in organizational security, privacy, and success, including how to systematically identify and mitigate risks, threats, and vulnerabilities
- Gained practical experience with Linux, SQL, Python and utilized SIEM tools, IDS, and network protocol analyzers for proactive threat management
- Applied knowledge to real-world scenarios, developing skills in proactive threat detection and response through completion of dynamic hands-on projects, including: conducting a simulated security audit, responding to a cyber incident, analyzing vulnerable systems, and completing an incident handler's journal

General Diploma • Benito Suarez Academy, Chicago, IL